Jewish language. Experience in the army helped to make the newly arrived Jews into true Israelis.

Many Israelis went to live and work on **kibbutzim**. These were large co-operative farms in which all the property and work was shared. Different families ate together and shared living quarters. With financial aid from the USA and **reparations** from Germany, the Israelis irrigated and cultivated vast areas of desert.

The state of Israel became richer, stronger and more highly developed in the 1950s and early 1960s. New industries, such as cars, chemicals and defence, were built and vast sums of money were spent on the armed forces to defend the country. The high level of education and skills of Israeli citizens played a major part in this development but the speed of the country's progress would not have been possible without huge gifts from abroad. Most of this aid came from the USA. In fact, the US government and American Jews sent about a billion dollars a year to Israel. The US government felt that Israel was a close, firm friend in a troubled part of the world and it knew that the Soviet Union was arming Egypt and Syria. It also knew that the Arab states were united in their opposition to the state of Israel.

Key terms

Kibbutzim
Settlements in Israel where people live and work together.

Reparations
Damages or compensation which Germany paid to Israel for the persecution of the Jews during the Second World War.

The Palestine Liberation Organisation (PLO)

At their meeting in Cairo in 1964, the leaders of the Arab states had stated:

> The existence of Israel is a danger that threatens the Arab nation. Collective Arab military preparations, when they are completed, will constitute the ultimate practical means for the final liquidation of Israel.

Key question
What part did Fatah play in the developing conflict between Israel and its Arab neighbours?

This may have been just rhetoric, or bold talk, to enable the Arab states to show a united front but it was the first time that they had declared, in an official document, that their ultimate aim was the destruction of Israel. The Arab leaders went on to set up the Palestine Liberation Organisation (PLO) whose aim was to win back the land which the Palestinians had lost in 1948–9. In 1965 a guerrilla group called **Fatah**, which was part of the PLO, carried out its first raid on Israel. Fatah had its bases in three of the Arab countries that bordered Israel: Syria, Jordan and Lebanon. This group carried out many armed raids into Israel over the next few years. Israeli retaliation for Fatah raids was usually swift and harsh.

Key term

Fatah
A Palestinian guerrilla group founded by Yasser Arafat. Its general strategy was to drag the Arab states into war with Israel so that a Palestinian state might be established.

The governments of Lebanon and Jordan tried to restrict PLO activities because they were afraid of Israeli reprisals. The Syrians, however, were keen to support the PLO. They encouraged Fatah's raids against Israel and supplied men and arms. The only neighbouring state from which Israel was not attacked was Egypt. This was because UN troops had been placed on the border between Egypt and Israel after the 1956 war to prevent further clashes.

Key dates

Palestine Liberation Organisation (PLO) established: 1964

Fatah carried out its first raid on Israel: 1965